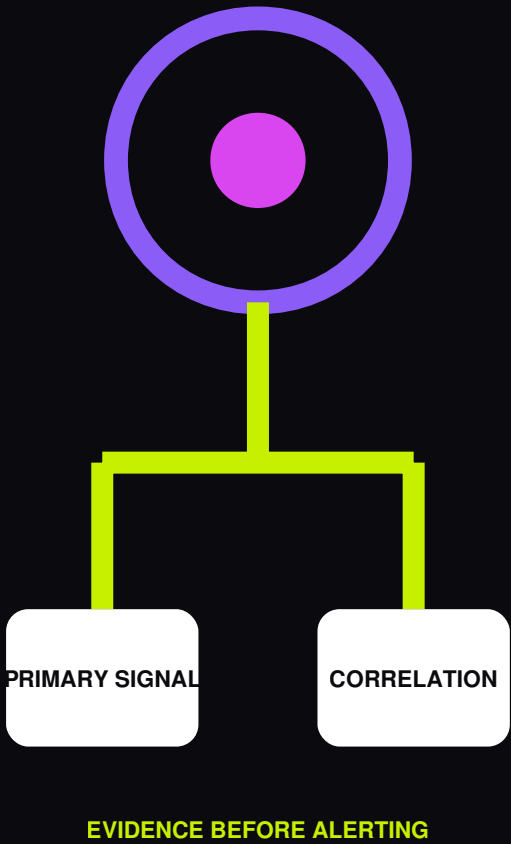


HIDDEN APPLICATION SUPPORT EXECUTION

Hunts for AccountsHelper or mdworker_shared executing from the two hidden Apple-lookalike Application Support directories observed in the Unit 42 lab infection.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



REPORT DATE	STATUS
17 September 2026	Untested implementation sketch
PRIMARY PLATFORM	OPERATIONAL VALUE
Microsoft Defender XDR	9.5 / 10



EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.5

Hunts for AccountsHelper or mdworker_shared executing from the two hidden Apple-lookalike Application Support directories observed in the Unit 42 lab infection.

STATUS

Hunting query

Untested implementation sketch; Confidence Medium.

1primary table

0joins

0secondary rules

2validation gates

Evidence boundary

A match establishes execution from a source-observed path. It does not prove credential theft, persistence success, archive contents, C2 or exfiltration.



BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from analytical scope.

MECHANICS

Source-supported fact

- 1 Unit 42 published the analysis on 16 September 2026; the lab infection occurred on 5 August 2026.
- 2 A .service shell script ran AccountsHelper from .com.apple.accountsd.
- 3 A .mdworker shell script ran mdworker_shared from .com.apple.metadata.mds.

Detection hypothesis

If an attacker repeats this behavior, CloudAppEvents should expose the same source-supported identity or content-access pattern. Distinction requires ownership, change, device, sign-in, and approved-automation context.

Unconfirmed elements

A match establishes execution from a source-observed path. It does not prove credential theft, persistence success, archive contents, C2 or exfiltration.

Logic: Campaign-specific artifact + process execution **ATT&CK:** T1059.004 · T1036



TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Collection prerequisites and field reliability.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED
Microsoft Defender for Endpoint on macOS with DeviceProcessEvents preserving process filename and full folder path.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT
DeviceFileEvents, process ancestry, signer/hash, file prevalence, device owner and network telemetry.

Fields	Reliability	Use
Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, ReportId	Documented	Query or triage
FileName, FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine	Documented	Query or triage
Initiating-process fields, SHA1, SHA256	Documented	Query or triage
Two exact name/path pairs	Present in source	Query or triage
macOS field population and retention	Environment-dependent	Query or triage

Excluded
No message body, phishing-page content, inferred success, actor attribution, or undocumented cross-SIEM mapping is used.



PRIMARY KQL

Direct source-supported conditions with investigable output.

HUNTING

STATUS

Hunting query — Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where
  (FileName == "AccountsHelper" and
    FolderPath endswith
      "/Library/Application Support/.com.apple.accountsd")
  or
  (FileName == "mdworker_shared" and
    FolderPath endswith
      "/Library/Application Support/.com.apple.metadata.mds")
| project Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName,
  AccountName, FileName, FolderPath,
  ProcessCommandLine,
  InitiatingProcessFileName,
  InitiatingProcessCommandLine,
  SHA1, SHA256, ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

WINDOW

None

THRESHOLD

None

JOIN

None

KEY

DeviceId +
Timestamp +
ReportId



TRIAGE AND TUNING

Human validation before response.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain raw event, entity, timestamps, correlation identifiers and surrounding context.

2

Confirm

Identify the user, device or service owner, origin and approved change record.

3

Enrich

DeviceFileEvents, process ancestry, signer/hash, file prevalence, device owner and network telemetry.

4

Scope

Review adjacent identity, endpoint and network evidence without expanding beyond observed facts.

Expected benign overlap

Authorized red-team exercises, malware labs or software intentionally replicating the artifacts. Require owner, package origin, signer/hash and change evidence.

Response boundary

A match establishes execution from a source-observed path. It does not prove credential theft, persistence success, archive contents, C2 or exfiltration.



VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and cross-SIEM limits.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

- 1. Confirm MDE macOS DeviceProcessEvents coverage.
- 2. Run inert binaries with both source-observed name/path pairs.
- 3. Verify spaces, case, path completeness and parent context.
- 4. Measure 30 days and attribute every historical hit.

Decision criteria

Success: Both controlled executions produce complete events and historical hits are absent or attributable.

Rejection: Paths are truncated or legitimate overlap cannot be separated.

Failure: macOS is not onboarded or process events are not retained.

Platform	Decision	Missing evidence
Defender XDR	Hunting query	Target execution and baseline
Splunk	No reliable implementation	Index, sourcetype, parser, sample
Chronicle	No reliable implementation	Parser and exact UDM mapping



CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Hunting query

Hunts for AccountsHelper or mdworker_shared executing from the two hidden Apple-lookalike Application Support directories observed in the Unit 42 lab infection.

A match establishes execution from a source-observed path. It does not prove credential theft, persistence success, archive contents, C2 or exfiltration.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1059.004 · T1036

References

1. Unit 42 — Atomic macOS (AMOS) Stealer Activity — 16 Sep 2026
2. Microsoft — DeviceProcessEvents schema — accessed 17 Sep 2026
3. MITRE ATT&CK — T1059.004 Unix Shell
4. MITRE ATT&CK — T1036 Masquerading

Document control

English dossier. No customer data. URLs are defanged in references.txt. HTML and rendering assets remain private.